



Five Tips to Enhance Patient Communication at the Bedside

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Effective and compassionate patient communication is an essential component of bedside medicine that helps develop stronger patient-physician relationships. It also encourages patients to be more engaged in their healthcare, which promotes better health outcomes.

Those who are familiar with Stanford Medicine 25 and our mission know that we frequently discuss this critical subject, touching on both basic skills and more nuanced communication.

Our previous blog posts have addressed a range of related themes, including [communication strategies to help physicians lead meaningful patient conversations](#), [telehealth tips to preserve key aspects of patient care](#) and

guidance on [tackling difficult patient conversations](#).

Given the magnitude of this topic, we believe it's a worthwhile one to revisit frequently!

Following, we've developed a list of five key communication tactics to remember in your next patient interaction.



Tip 1: Cultivate a positive connection at the beginning of each patient encounter.

"Making a positive connection is not always easy, especially when our days are rushed and we are stressed and distracted, but each encounter should set the stage for respectful communication," explain Shannon J. Voogt, MD, Kelli Pratt, DO, and Amber Rollet, MD, in an [article](#) for the American Academy of Family Physicians.

They recommend beginning patient interactions by warmly introducing yourself and your role while maintaining eye contact. It can be helpful to ask how the patient would like to be addressed and acknowledge anyone accompanying them. Taking an additional moment to make a non-medical connection can also be impactful – try commenting on or asking a question about a neutral topic, such as the weather or sports.

Tip 2: Engage with the patient's story.

In an [article](#) for the American Medical Association, Randa Zalman emphasizes the importance of giving patients undivided attention while listening carefully to their story. What can you learn about them as a whole person and their background? What do they do for work, and what hobbies do they enjoy? What are their goals for their health? Tapping into this not only helps you develop a stronger rapport, but it also can inform a more effective care plan that is tailored to their lifestyle and preferences. As Zalman explains, asking "What can I do to help you?" is a simple way to spark conversation while also displaying a genuine interest in the patient's perspective. This list of open-ended questions by Penn Medicine's Jeffrey Millstein, MD, via Closler, may also be a helpful resource.

Tip 3: Refine your persona and interpersonal skills.

As LaQuana L. Smith, RN V, describes in a [piece](#) for the American Nurse Journal, being mindful of your body language and tone of voice can enhance interactions. Is your tone warm and inviting? Does your body language convey a sense of openness? Do you allow your patient to speak without interruption? Sitting at eye level with your patient and maintaining eye contact can support these interactions.



Tip 4: Demonstrate cultural and diversity competence.

Demonstrate cultural and diversity competence. Both cultural and diversity competence play important roles in providing person-centered care. Cultural, racial and ethnic backgrounds, disabilities, sexual orientation or gender identity, can impact how individuals experience healthcare. As outlined in a previous Stanford Medicine 25 [blog post](#), physicians can refine knowledge in this area by studying personal beliefs and culture, participating in cultural training and engaging with local communities.



Tip 5: Demonstrate compassion and empathy

Many of the greats in bedside medicine have underscored the importance of genuine care for the patient. In

1927, Boston City Hospital's Francis Weld Peabody, MD, stated "One of the essential qualities of the clinician is an interest in humanity, for the secret of the care of the patient is in caring for the patient." While empathy is often overlooked as an innate, soft skill, a Stanford Medicine 25 [blog](#) from our archives explores how this quality can and should be cultivated in medical education.

As you move forward with these strategies in mind, consider these words from Canadian physician Sir William Osler that highlight the importance of humanity in patient care: ***"The good physician treats the disease; the great physician treats the patient who has the disease."***

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